thinking and cooperative action are the basis for greater community awareness. And the strongest arguments in favour lie in the ocean's history.

The Indian Ocean 'world' did once have an essential unity that was based on maritime trade rhythms. We also know that it was indeed a self-sustaining zone, albeit with natural and flexible boundaries, that set it apart from others proximate. The association of maritime trade with cultural influence was both graphic and pervasive across the ocean. As a result, traditions, practices, faiths and commerce created a virtual connectivity that overcame distance. The romance of history, however, had to give way to the realities of international relations as the arrival of the Europeans fragmented the ocean and its littoral. The postcolonial world also created new national, and thereafter, regional identities that put the ocean in the shade. Moreover, economic activity and cultural habits specific to the coast in the Indian Ocean did not always extend very far inland. This lack of depth perhaps also contributed to the strategic reduction of an entire eco-system into just a water space. The tension between socio-economics and geopolitics was largely responsible for this situation. Today, as the latter changes dramatically, the Indian Ocean cannot remain impervious.

As oceans go, the Indian Ocean is one that has been the beneficiary of a millennia of culture. While its fundamental economic activities directly derived from cycles of nature, these were also carried over into traditions. As a result, the ocean evolved its own special identity that is based on mobility, acceptance and inter-penetration. This historical inheritance is visible across its expanse, from Hindu temples in Bali and My Son, in fact all the way up to Zhengzhou on the Fujian coast of China; in Arab communities in Aceh and eastern Sri Lanka, or the Waqwaq settlers in Madagascar. Indeed, there are few more striking examples of global trends being expressed through the region as local presence. The remnants of influence after so many centuries only give us a partial sense of the intensity and vibrancy of what it must have been once. That they still tell their tale testifies to the fact that the overall ethos of the Indian Ocean was one of co-existence and adjustment, where respect for diversity was intrinsic to the promotion of trade. To revive a better sense of its own identity, it is important to appreciate and foster this multi-chromatic picture of the Indian Ocean.